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African urban life: the transformation of Ouagadougou

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Catholics are buried in a number of burial grounds around Ouagadougou, including the main cemetery near the mission and the cemetery behind the Dapoya II parish church. The Church does not interfere in the family rituals (such as the role of the *dakiba* [joking relatives], the preparation of the body, and matters of this kind) which take place within the confines of the homes of the deceased. The clergy hold burial services for the deceased in the church and then preside at the final religious rites at the grave. However, they leave rather quickly after this rite is over so that even good Catholics can perform such traditional rituals as placing wearing apparel and food utensils on the graves of the deceased. The Church does encourage Catholics to light candles for the deceased, and to have Masses said for the soul of the departed in lieu of spending money for the more expensive traditional funerals (*kouré*). Nevertheless, Mossi Catholics in Ouagadougou do have modified versions of traditional funerals at which friends gather, the dead are spoken about, joking relatives appear and make people laugh by their antics, and where people drink *dolo* and dance in the name of the deceased. But sacrifices are never made to the ancestors, at least not publicly, since it would be considered un-Catholic to do so.

[764](#)
[Burial Practices And](#)
[Funerals](#)

[769](#)
[Cult Of The Dead](#)

[797](#)
[Missions](#)

Protestants

The first Protestant American Assemblies of God missionaries arrived in Ouagadougou around 1922 to 1923 from their base in Senegal. By the end of 1923, six missionaries were listed as resident in the town, but by 1929, two had left to establish mission stations in other parts of Mossi country. The Protestants had difficulty gaining their first converts among [334](#) the Ouagadougou population. In one of their early reports they complained

[175](#)
[History](#)

[795](#)
[Religious](#)
[Denominations](#)

that, in addition to being the headquarters of the French administration and the capital of the Mogho Naba, Ouagadougou was "also the headquarters of the Catholic Mission which has been here for about thirty-five years. These all have considerable influence on the natives, making the work of evangelization more difficult here than in other centers, and the visible fruit for the labor bestowed less."³⁰ After much effort, the Protestants finally did gain some converts. Here, too, the desire among Africans for education appears to have helped. The report added that,

For several years now, a number of young men who were attending school in Ouagadougou came to the French Bible class, but just recently some of the natives in the government employ have also become interested and joined the class. At this station, we are having Bible classes most every day, three of these classes being in French. Some of our more advanced Christians have taken over the teaching of reading and writing, and every night when they are free, they go to villages and preach the Word.³¹

³⁰"The Assemblies of God in Foreign Lands, The Gospel among the Mossi People." Foreign Missions Department, General Council of the Assemblies of God (Springfield, Missouri, 1934), p. 13.

³¹*Ibid.*

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